

Two Men, One Gospel

Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

Full Sermon Manuscript — Long Version (Reducible to 30 Minutes)

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Preaching note: This manuscript is written at approximately 45–50 minutes of speaking content. Sections marked [CUT FOR 30 MIN] can be omitted without breaking the argument. The core 30-minute flow is preserved in the draft script.

Opening: The Last Roll Call

I want to begin in a room.

It is Rome. Not the Rome of the Colosseum and the Trevi Fountain and the piazzas where tourists now take photographs. This is the Rome of Nero — the Rome of dungeons and midnight arrests and Christians who disappeared. It is approximately AD 67.

Paul is in his second Roman imprisonment. This is not the house arrest of Acts 28, where he received visitors and preached freely while chained to a guard. That season has passed. This is something colder. A cell. Stone walls. The smell of damp and fear. Execution is close enough that Paul can taste it. He knows it, and he writes in these pages with the particular clarity of a man who has stopped pretending he has more time than he does.

He writes what will be his last letter. And near the end of that letter — 2 Timothy, chapter 4 — he does something unremarkable and devastating at the same time: he takes attendance.

Let me read it to you. 2 Timothy 4, beginning at verse 9:

"Do thy diligence to come shortly unto me: For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world, and is departed unto Thessalonica; Crescens to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. Only Luke is with me."

Stop there.

Two men. Two names. Same mission field. Same apostle. Same prison context. Same world pulling at both of them.

Demas. Luke.

One drifted. One stayed.

And I want to tell you this morning that the difference between those two men is not talent. It is not theological sophistication. It is not even the outward appearance of faith. The difference is the location of their love.

That is the whole sermon. Everything I say for the next thirty minutes is an expansion of that sentence. Two men. One gospel. The question of where they placed their love.

I. The Three Mentions — Reading the Arc

Before I go anywhere else, I need to show you something about the biblical record of Demas. Because the tragedy of Demas is not visible in a single text. You have to read the arc.

Demas appears in exactly three places in the New Testament. And those three appearances tell a story that a single snapshot could never reveal.

The first appearance. Philemon 1:24.

Paul is writing to Philemon — a letter about the runaway slave Onesimus. Paul is in captivity at this point, first Roman imprisonment. He closes the letter with greetings, and he lists the people around him:

"Marcus, Aristarchus, Demas, Lucas, my fellow labourers."

Fellow laborer. That is the word. Demas is not a peripheral figure. He is not a sympathizer or an occasional attendee. He is a *fellow laborer* — the same language Paul uses for Timothy, for Titus, for the closest members of his missionary circle. Demas is inside the tent.

The second appearance. Colossians 4:14.

Same period, roughly. Paul writes to the Colossian church, and again he sends greetings from the people around him. *"Luke the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you."*

Notice something. Demas is still there. Still named. Still present. And he is listed in the same breath as Luke — "the beloved physician," the man who will figure prominently in the other half of this sermon.

There is no warning sign here. None. No asterisk. No "Demas, who I am beginning to have concerns about." He is simply present, trusted, and named.

The third appearance. 2 Timothy 4:10.

Years later. Paul's second imprisonment. The final letter. And now: *"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world."*

Gone.

The Greek is precise and painful. *Agapēsas ton nun aiōna* — "having loved this present age." The verb *agapēsas* is the aorist participle of *agapaō* — the word of John 3:16. The word of the Great Commandment — "thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart." The word Jesus uses when he asks Peter three times on the shore: "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?"

Paul does not say Demas feared the present world. He does not say Demas enjoyed the world, or chose the world under duress. He says Demas *loved* it. He applied to the passing age the very word that belongs to God.

And the noun — *aiōna* — is equally important. It is not merely "the world" in the sense of geography or pleasure. The Greek *aiōn* refers to the entire current age — its values, its systems, its way of measuring what matters and what does not. Demas did not embrace paganism. He embraced the *aiōn* — the present world's ordering of reality — as his deepest love.

Now here is what I need you to hold: **between the second mention and the third mention, nothing dramatic happened.** Paul does not say Demas was seduced by a specific temptation. He does not say Demas experienced a crisis of faith. There is no theological argument, no recorded scandal, no sudden apostasy.

He just... drifted.

This was not an acute event. It was a chronic condition of the soul. And if you understand that, you will understand why this story is dangerous — not for the people we consider to be on the edge of the church, but for the people sitting right here. People who were named. People who were trusted. People who were present.

II. The Anatomy of Drift

Let me be a physician for a moment.

In medicine, we distinguish between acute and chronic conditions. A heart attack announces itself. Chest pain, diaphoresis, jaw radiation, the sudden sensation that something catastrophic has happened. It is impossible to miss an acute myocardial infarction when it arrives.

But the process that leads to a heart attack — coronary artery disease — is silent. Plaque accumulates over decades. Vessels narrow incrementally. Perfusion drops so slowly that the heart develops collateral circulation to compensate. A person can have severe, life-limiting coronary disease and feel entirely well, because the deterioration has been so gradual that the body has adapted around it.

By the time the acute event arrives, the chronic process has been underway for twenty, thirty years.

Demas did not have an acute spiritual event. He had a chronic condition of the soul. The departure from Paul — the final mention — was the myocardial infarction. But the coronary artery disease had been developing quietly through every small choice, every incremental prioritization, every morning when the world got his best energy and Christ got what was left.

I want to name three diagnoses in the Demas condition. Not because the labels are the point — but because if we can name what happened to him, we have a fighting chance of seeing it in ourselves.

Diagnosis 1: Urgency Becomes Background Music

Demas heard Paul preach. He was there when Paul stood in the synagogues and the marketplaces and the courtyards and said: *The present world is passing away. Christ is coming. The kingdom of God is at hand.* Demas witnessed the urgency that drove Paul to travel forty thousand miles on foot and by boat, to endure stonings and shipwrecks and imprisonment, to write letters that would outlast every empire.

He heard it. He believed it. For a while.

But somewhere in the trajectory from Philemon to 2 Timothy, the eschatological urgency faded to background music. *Soon* became *eventually*. *The world is passing away* became *the world is the context in which I am building my life*. The present age, which was supposed to feel temporary and subordinate, started to feel permanent and primary.

Ellen White, in *The Great Controversy*, describes this shift as one of Satan's most effective strategies — not direct assault on doctrine, but the subtle distortion of priority, so that eternal things feel distant and present things feel urgent. She writes that Satan works to distort the character of God — to make Him seem remote or irrelevant — in order to break our focus and prevent the kind of close, personal relationship that would keep us anchored.

This is what I want to ask you — and I am asking myself alongside you: **When did you last feel the urgency you felt the first time you understood what the gospel actually meant?**

That first love is always urgent love. It is love that reorganizes everything — priorities, time, money, energy. When that urgency fades to background music, you have not lost your theology. You have lost the *fire* in it. And theology without fire is a map without a destination.

Diagnosis 2: Good Work Replaces First Love

Here is what is subtle about the Demas case: he was not idle when he drifted. He went to Thessalonica. Thessalonica was not a vacation. It was a city — a city with a church Paul had founded, with contacts and opportunities, with meaningful work to be done.

Demas did not stop working for God. He stopped being with God. And in the space between those two things, the work became the replacement rather than the expression of love.

This is the Laodicean parallel. And I want to spend a moment here because it is textually grounded, not merely illustrative.

In Colossians 4 — the same letter where Demas appears healthy and present — Paul instructs the Colossian church: *"when this epistle is read among you, cause that it be read also in the church of the Laodiceans."* The letter that carries Demas's name traveled to Laodicea. The church that Christ addresses in Revelation 3 received a document that mentioned, by name, a man who was already in the early stages of his drift.

And what does Christ say to Laodicea? *"I know thy works."* He does not say, "I see your absence." He says "I know your works" — and then the diagnosis arrives: *"thou art neither cold nor hot."* You say you are rich, you have need of nothing. You have mistaken productivity for proximity. You have confused the activity of the church for the presence of Christ.

The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion. It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart.

I have seen this in medicine, and I have seen it in ministry. A person who is too busy for prayer is not always idle — often they are working harder than anyone around them. The busyness is real, the work is good, and the heart has slowly and silently moved. Ellen White saw this pattern clearly. She writes in *Testimonies*, volume 5: "Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity."

She did not say "the love of evil." She said "the cares of this life." Good things. Necessary things. Things that crowd.

Diagnosis 3: The Love Question Has No Substitute

In John 21, Christ appears to Peter on the shore after the resurrection. Peter, who denied Christ three times. Peter, who wept bitterly. Peter, who has spent the time between the crucifixion and this moment — going back to fishing.

And Jesus does not come to Peter with a performance review. He does not ask: How many people have you told about the resurrection? Have you rebuilt your prayer life? Do you have a plan for the next five years of ministry? He asks one question. Three times.

"Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?"

The word varies subtly in the Greek between the questions — *agapa*■ and *phile*■ — and scholars debate the significance. But the core movement is unmistakable: Jesus wants to know where Peter's love is. Not his activity. Not his intention. Not his theology. His love.

The prescription Christ gave to the church at Ephesus — the church that had left its first love — was the same. *Remember. Repent. Return.* Three commands. Not "work harder." Not "reform your doctrine." *Return to the love you had at first.*

What would you struggle to surrender if Christ asked for it this week? Not the things you know you should surrender. The things you actually love. The question is searching, and it should be.

III. The Anatomy of Fidelity — Luke

[CUT FOR 30 MIN: begin this section at "Luke shows up."]

Now I want to turn from Demas to Luke. Not to make Luke a hero in the comic-book sense — because the point is not to create a character to admire from a distance. The point is to understand what produced Luke's fidelity, so that we can ask whether the same thing is operating in us.

Luke was a physician. In the first-century Roman world, that meant education, professional options, and genuine mobility. A physician with Luke's training and cultural capital could have found a patron, established a practice in any major city of the empire, and done meaningful work without ever setting foot near a condemned prisoner. The world was available to Luke in ways that it simply was not available to most of the people who followed Paul.

He chose the prison cell.

Two Timothy 4:11: *"Only Luke is with me."*

Luke shows up in the text at the moment when everyone else has departed or been sent elsewhere. Demas to Thessalonica. Crescens to Galatia. Titus to Dalmatia. Tychicus to Ephesus. When the fellowship of the mission field empties out, Luke is still there.

I want to give you three things that explain that fidelity — not as an exhaustive psychological portrait, but as three practical anchors that held where Demas's did not.

Luke 1: He Wrote Himself Out of His Own Narrative

Read the Gospel of Luke carefully. Read the book of Acts. Luke is the author of both — that is the near-unanimous consensus of scholarship and tradition. He is present in the "we" passages of Acts — those sections where the first-person plural suddenly appears: *"we sailed," "we stayed at Philippi," "we were caught in the storm."* Luke is there, in the scene, firsthand.

But his name never appears. Not in the Gospel. Not in Acts. He writes himself into the story only through that quiet, repeated "we" — and even then, he never says "I, Luke, was there." He documents faithfully and disappears.

Richard Bauckham, in his study of the eyewitness testimony behind the Gospels, observes that Luke's practice of erasing his own name reflects a deliberate authorial humility. He is present, but he is not the point. The story he is telling is Someone else's story, and he refuses to let his own presence become a distraction from it.

This is the disposition that holds under pressure. Not self-erasure — Luke clearly has a distinct voice, a precise mind, a physician's eye for human detail. But self-subordination. The self placed in proper relationship to Christ, so that the story being told is not about what Luke is accomplishing, but about what Christ has accomplished.

Demas, we can infer, had reached a point where his story needed to go somewhere. Where the mission field no longer served his narrative. Where Thessalonica — with its opportunities and its safety and its sense of a life being built — was more compelling than the script of suffering in Rome.

Luke 2: He Practiced What He Documented

Luke's Gospel contains the parable of the Prodigal Son — the father running to meet the returning child, the robe and the ring and the feast for the one who was lost. He recorded the healing of the woman bent double for eighteen years — the compassion of Christ for human suffering that defies both disease and

religious protocol. He preserved the journey to Emmaus — two disciples walking away from Jerusalem in despair, and a Stranger who opened the Scriptures until their hearts burned within them.

Luke wrote these things down. And then he lived in proximity to a man who was going to die.

The physician who had documented Christ's compassion for the suffering stayed with a suffering man. The historian who had recorded the disciples' fear in Gethsemane stayed in a place of fear. The writer who had preserved the words "*If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me*" — he carried his cross. Daily. Into a Roman prison.

There is an integrity in Luke that we do not often name: the integrity between the theology he wrote and the life he lived. Ellen White captures this when she writes in *The Acts of the Apostles* that Luke's services were "a great comfort to Paul" — not merely professional services, but the comfort of a presence that had not been bought by the easier option.

Luke 3: He Carried the "Only"

"Only Luke is with me."

The word *monos* — only, alone, solitary. Three words in English. One word doing enormous work in Greek.

I want you to think about what that sentence meant to Paul. Not as a literary notation but as a pastoral experience. Paul is in a cold cell. His execution is coming. The circle of his life's work has scattered — some gone legitimately, sent on mission; some gone like Demas, following the pull of the world. And in that moment, one man's presence is the entire embodiment of the church, the gospel, the fellowship of the Holy Spirit.

Only Luke.

Luke did not know, when he stayed, that this was the sentence that would carry his name through twenty centuries of Christian reading. He stayed because staying was faithful. He stayed because Paul needed someone to stay. He stayed because his love for Christ had not been displaced by his love for the present world.

And in staying, he became Paul's *only*.

There is someone in your life — perhaps in your congregation, perhaps in your family, perhaps in the margin of your professional world — for whom your staying, your presence, your faithfulness will be the *only*. The only person who came to the hospital. The only person who did not withdraw when the circumstances became uncomfortable. The only person who kept showing up.

You will not receive a congratulatory plaque for being someone's only. The moment will probably not feel significant. But I am telling you this morning, on the authority of this text: Luke did not feel the weight of that "only" when he chose to stay. He only knew it in retrospect. And perhaps we will only know ours the same way.

IV. The Interior Turn

[DO NOT CUT THIS SECTION — give it full space]

I need to step out from behind the text for a moment.

I am a physician. I build things. I move fast across multiple domains — clinical work, teaching, writing, ministry. I serve as an elder in this church tradition. I preach, I write, I carry multiple missions simultaneously. And I am telling you — from personal testimony, not from a safe distance — that the Demas condition is not something I observe in other people and then come to warn you about.

It is something I feel.

Not toward obvious sin. Not toward anything that would show up on a moral inventory. Toward something quieter and more personal: the satisfaction of a productive week that had very little room for the actual presence of God. The week where the theology was correct — the Sabbath was kept, the sermon was prepared, the devotional was written — and yet somewhere in the volume of it, Christ had moved from the center of my love to the object of my professional attention.

That is the Demas condition. It is not rebellion. It is drift. And drift, by its nature, is invisible until the distance has become significant.

I am not telling you this to create a dramatic moment of pastoral vulnerability. I am telling you because if I can feel this pull — having spent years studying exactly this text — then the pull is real for everyone in this room. The question is not whether we have drifted. The question is whether we are honest enough to stop and ask where we are standing right now.

Not where we were when we first gave our hearts to Christ. Not where we plan to be after we finish the current season of building. Right now. Today. Sabbath morning in Braselton, Georgia.

Where is your love?

V. The Prescription — Remember, Repent, Return

[CUT FOR 30 MIN: shorten the Laodicean section; keep the three commands and the close]

The Laodicean letter in Revelation 3 does not end with diagnosis. I want to be clear about that, because the weight of this sermon has been heavy and I do not want to leave you in the diagnosis without offering what Christ actually offers.

The letter ends with prescription.

"I counsel thee to buy of me gold tried in the fire, that thou mayest be rich; and white raiment, that thou mayest be clothed, and that the shame of thy nakedness do not appear; and anoint thine eyes with eyesalve, that thou mayest see."

And then — just before the close of the letter — one of the most searching images in all of Revelation: *"Behold, I stand at the door, and knock."*

Christ is not standing outside the door of unbelievers in this verse. He is standing outside the door of a church. The Laodicean church is still meeting, still worshipping, still identifying as God's people — and Christ is outside, knocking for re-entry into his own community. That is the Demas condition at its fullest expression: a community that has the name of Christ but has quietly moved him from the center.

Ellen White's counsel on Laodicea is that the eyesalve — the spiritual vision that comes only from the Holy Spirit — is the remedy. The eyesalve restores two things simultaneously: the ability to see Christ's beauty, and the ability to see one's own need. Both are lost in the drift. When we drift, Christ seems less compelling — because we have stopped seeing Him clearly — and our own need seems smaller, because we have surrounded ourselves with the evidence of our own competence.

To the Ephesian church, Christ offered three commands. They are simple, and I will not complicate them.

Remember. Where were you when the fire was first lit? When the gospel first broke through? When you first understood that Christ had died specifically for you — not for humanity in general, but for you, by name? Return to that memory. Not as nostalgia, but as diagnosis. The distance between who you were then and who you are now is the measure of the drift.

Repent. Not in the sense of groveling or self-punishment. In the sense of *turning*. The Greek word *metanoeo* — a change of mind, a change of direction. Turn back toward what you turned away from. The direction is the act of repentance, not the emotional intensity that accompanies it.

Return. Do the first works. Not different works — the first ones. The works that came from love rather than duty. The prayer that was conversation rather than obligation. The Scripture that was nourishment rather than material. The worship that was encounter rather than attendance.

Closing: Which Man Are You Becoming?

The sermon is almost done. But the trajectory continues.

You will leave this building in a few hours. You will return to the *ai■n* — the present age, the same age that claimed Demas. Your phone will notify you. Your Monday will present itself. The world will resume making its case for why it deserves your deepest love.

And you will make choices. Small ones. Probably invisible to everyone around you. But they are, in aggregate, the answer to the question that underlies everything we have said this morning:

Which man am I becoming?

Not "which man am I today" — because on any given day, we are all something of both. But becoming. The trajectory. The direction of drift.

Luke's faithfulness was not a single heroic decision. It was a daily reorientation. *Kath' h■meran* — "daily," the word in Luke 9:23. Daily. Take up the cross daily. Return to the center daily. Choose first love daily.

Ellen White writes in *Steps to Christ* that the disciples of Christ "behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure." She is describing what first love looks like when it is alive — when the center has not moved, when the eye has not grown dim, when the *agap■sas* has not been redirected to the passing age.

That is available to you. Today.

Not because you have earned the return. Not because you have perfected the discipline. But because Christ is still standing at the door. And He is still knocking.

Go love Him first.

Not in your own strength — because Demas had that, too, for a while. In the strength of the One who stayed when we drifted. Who came when we departed. Who loved us with the word He asked us to give back to Him.

Luke stayed. So can you.

Remember. Repent. Return.

Close in prayer. Not for success. Not for productivity. Not for a better week. Pray for reordered love.

Structural Summary

| Section | Content | Long Version | 30-Min Version | |---|---|---|---| | Opening | Paul's last dispatch; two names | 5 min | 3 min | | I. Three Mentions | Biblical arc of Demas; Luke's parallel | 6 min | 5 min | | II. Anatomy of Drift | Three diagnoses | 12 min | 8 min | | III. Anatomy of Fidelity | Three things Luke demonstrates | 12 min | 7 min | | IV. Interior Turn | Physician self-implication | 5 min | 4 min | | V. Prescription | Remember, Repent, Return | 6 min | 3 min | | **TOTAL** | | **~46 min** | **~30 min** |